

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1037

By Jones J

A RESOLUTION to commemorate the eightieth anniversary of
Philippine-American Friendship Day.

WHEREAS, on July 4, 1946, following Japan's defeat in World War II, the United States formally recognized the independence of the Philippines, marking the birth of the Republic of the Philippines after years of colonial rule and the trials of World War II; and

WHEREAS, the 1946 Treaty of Manila officially relinquished United States sovereignty over the Philippines, and the date of July 4 was celebrated as Independence Day in the Philippines from 1946 to 1961; and

WHEREAS, today, July 4 is observed in the Philippines as Philippine-American Friendship Day, a day that pays tribute to the long partnership between the two nations; and

WHEREAS, this partnership was strengthened during World War II, when President Franklin D. Roosevelt ordered to duty the Philippine Scouts, the Philippine Commonwealth Army, and the Philippine Constabulary to defend the Philippines and the United States against the Imperial Japanese military forces; and

WHEREAS, more than 260,000 Filipinos fought during the four-year campaign, resulting in some 57,000 killed and thousands more wounded; the Japanese invasion resulted in the capture of approximately 76,000 American and Filipino prisoners of war who endured the Bataan Death March; and

WHEREAS, among those who distinguished themselves throughout the war was Magdalena E. Leones, who was the only Asian woman awarded the Silver Star during World War II, the third-highest honor for valor in the United States Army, in recognition of her gallantry and service; and

WHEREAS, similarly demonstrating courage and devotion to duty was Master Sergeant Aaron Kliatchko, known as the "Rabbi of Cabanatuan," who volunteered as an American intelligence agent when the Japanese invaded the Philippines in December 1941 and fought the invading forces on the Bataan peninsula; in 1948, he was posthumously awarded the Medal of Freedom, the highest honor the United States can bestow upon a civilian; and

WHEREAS, Philippine-American Friendship Day provides an opportunity to remember the sacrifices and solidarity that have shaped the diplomatic relationship between the two nations and to look forward to continued cooperation and friendship; and

WHEREAS, the Filipino population in Tennessee exceeds 30,000, making it the third-largest Asian ethnic group in the State, and this vibrant community enriches the civic, cultural, and economic life of Tennessee; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we commemorate the eightieth anniversary of Philippine-American Friendship Day, recognize the enduring partnership between the Republic of the Philippines and the United States of America, and extend our appreciation to the Filipino community in Tennessee for its many contributions to this State.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.